

By Sharda Ugra

The Commonwealth Co-Ordination Commission (Co-Com) was in session at the convention hall of Delhi's Ashok Hotel. Speeches had been made and the burning issues of the controversy-magnet called the 2010 Commonwealth Games were being discussed. One at a time, the leading lights of the Games Organising Committee sidled out of the hall, very clearly on high alert.

Outside, these men in suits were found in whispered huddles because a real crisis had broken out. It was not about the Games deadlines, or the Co-Com opinion or even a fractious Games CEO. For these men, what was under threat was something more personal, and therefore more precious—their own turf as India's most powerful Olympic sports administrators.

What emerged from that huddle in the hotel was a battle plan to tackle the bitter war declared upon them by the sports minister. M.S. Gill wants to rewrite the fine print in Indian sports administration. Its office bearers though, men who resent even a raised eyebrow, want to hold and control their own ground.

What began as an arm wrestle between Gill, Union minister for youth affairs and sport, and Suresh Kalmadi, president of the Indian Olympic Association (IOA), has turned into a boxing bout between the ministry and a phalanx of Kalmadi's allies. The allies comprise India's least successful but longest-serving sports bosses. Given that what is being sought is a limitation of the tenure of officials, no wonder everyone is involved.

There are many fronts in this battle. The Delhi High Court, currently hearing an extremely well-drafted PIL sends out a few tremors every week. Emergency missives have gone out to the International Olympic Committee (IOC) and appeals to the Prime Minister's Office. The documents being flung on either side include a revolutionary sports policy of 1975 put into permafrost a decade ago, the Olympic charter and a spate of e-mails.

SINGH (LEFT) AND KALMADI (CENTRE) AT THE IOA'S SOLIDARITY MEETING



The Tenure TUSSLE

The gloves come off all around as M.S. Gill takes on the long-reigning top bosses of sports federations

After Gill and Kalmadi the latest man in the headlights is Randhir Singh, India's sole IOC representative. He is accused of a 'conflict of interest' over the tenure issue, after he waved letters of support from the IOC and the president of the Olympic Council of Asia.

This week, 20 federation heads

squashed themselves into a room at the Commonwealth Games headquarters, including members of the Parliament, politicians from all parties, current bureaucrats and businessmen to demonstrate their solidarity against the ministry restoring the 1975 government guideline